

Negotiate your salary

What's the average salary range for a Graphic Designer in Chicago? Also, give me tips and go-to phrases for negotiating a higher salary or better benefits based on my background.



Tools



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 Average Salary for a Graphic Designer in Chicago (2025 Estimate):

Experience Level	Average Salary Range	
Entry-Level (0–2 years)	\$45,000 – \$58,000	
Mid-Level (3–5 years)	\$58,000 – \$75,000	
Senior-Level (6+ years)	\$75,000 – \$95,000+	
Freelance / Contract	\$25–\$75/hour (varies widely)	

 *Top employers or agencies may offer bonuses, stock options, flexible work, or creative freedom perks that influence total comp.*

tips for negotiating



Tips for Negotiating a Higher Salary or Better Benefits:

1. Know Your Value

Use your portfolio, education, certifications (like Adobe CC), and any UX/UI, animation, or branding work to justify top-of-range pay.

2. Benchmark the Market

Reference salary data from:

- Glassdoor
- Levels.fyi
- ALGA Design Census
- Creative Circle or The Creative Group

3. Highlight Your Edge

Are you a hybrid (e.g., designer + coder)? Strong at motion graphics? Bilingual? Those are leverage points.

go-to-phrases for salary negotiation



Go-To Phrases for Salary Negotiation:

To Ask for More Money:

"Based on my experience and the scope of this role, I was hoping we could discuss a salary closer to \$_____."

"Given the market rates in Chicago and the contributions I can bring to your team, is there flexibility on the starting salary?"

"I'm excited about this opportunity and would love to find a number that reflects both the role and the value I bring."

To Negotiate Benefits Instead:

"If budget is tight, would it be possible to revisit this in 6 months with a performance-based raise structure?"

"I'd be open to a slightly lower salary if there's flexibility in remote work, vacation, or professional development budget."

To Leverage Competing Offers (Tactfully):

"I've been fortunate to receive strong interest from other teams, but this role really stands out. If the offer could align more closely with the others financially, I'd love to move forward here."